provide information about the Supreme Being (***Brahman***), the soul (***atman***) and the relation between the two, the origin of the universe from *Brahman*, retributive causality (***karma***), transmigration (***samsara***) and the means to and nature of ultimate liberation from rebirth (***moksha***). *Vedantins* seek a systematic interpretation of the ***Upanishads***, believing that they have a unified overall meaning.

Whereas the theorists of ritual performance (***Purva-Mimamsakas***) were concerned with and insisted upon the primary meaningfulness of *Vedic* action-commands (*vidhi*) bearing on ritual actions, *Vedantins* focus upon the fact-asserting or descriptive texts (*arthavada*) referring to already existent entities or states of affairs, rather than 'things to be done' (*karya*). Both traditions developed sophisticated techniques of textual exegesis and argued about whether ritual performance is a path to salvation on its own in comparison with intuitive insight (***jnana***), devotion to God (*bhakti*) and divine grace (*prasada*).

All schools assume that effects do not differ essentially from their underlying or substrative causes. It follows that the cosmos is not essentially different from the Supreme Being that is its cause. ***Madhva*** is an exception here in that he thinks that God produces the cosmos out of eternally real prime matter that is distinct from him.

Further reading: Bartley 2002; Lipner 1986

Vijnanavada (*Yogacara*; *Cittamatra*): *Mahayana* Buddhist school denying that there are any physical objects. Our apparent experience of a physical world results from consciousness' appearing to itself in the form of ideas that we mistakenly interpret as standing for external objects. Having mentally constructed a world of objects, we imagine individual subjects perceiving it by acts of cognition. They claim that what is material cannot appear